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November 20, 2025

Hiring Committee
GiveWell
2443 Fillmore Street, #380-4603
San Francisco, CA 94115

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to express my interest in the Researcher position at GiveWell. I am a Ph.D. candidate in the Department of Economics at Johns Hopkins University (advisors: Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis), and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My primary specializations are macroeconomic modeling, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on the ability of macroeconomic models to generate empirically realistic distributions of wealth and income over the life cycle. A key driver of that work is modeling heterogeneity in the rate of return on assets, and understanding how return dispersion contributes to portfolio accumulation across households. These themes connect naturally to GiveWell's emphasis on grounding recommendations in rigorous empirical evidence, transparent assumptions, and careful modeling of heterogeneous impacts across populations.

In my job-market paper, I calibrate a life-cycle heterogeneous-agent model to match wealth moments from the Survey of Consumer Finances by allowing households to differ in their portfolio returns. The model helps explain observed wealth concentration and return dispersion. In a related research project using the Health and Retirement Study, I examine how trust influences both income growth and asset returns — finding a hump-shaped relationship for returns and characterizing the distribution of the persistent component of returns to net worth. These experiences have equipped me to: (i) frame research strategies and design modeling approaches; (ii) execute econometric and simulation analysis with large micro-data sets; and (iii) translate quantitative findings into clear, rigorous written deliverables for both academic and practitioner audiences.

I am particularly excited about GiveWell's mission of identifying the most cost-effective opportunities to improve global well-being. Much of my work involves building transparent, model-based frameworks to compare counterfactuals, assess welfare trade-offs, and make assumptions explicit — all central components of GiveWell's approach to evaluating interventions. I am especially motivated by the opportunity to combine rigorous empirical analysis with moral seriousness and intellectual honesty, working through uncertainty in a way that ultimately improves real-world outcomes.

I believe I would be a strong fit at GiveWell because:

1. My experience with structural modeling, simulation-based inference, and empirical validation aligns with GiveWell's approach to evaluating and comparing interventions using explicit, quantitative models.

2. My research on heterogeneity in economic outcomes prepares me to assess how interventions affect different populations — an important consideration in modeling impact, external validity, and cost-effectiveness.
3. I bring a commitment to clarity, transparency, and careful reasoning, which are essential for producing public-facing research that others can understand, scrutinize, and build upon.

I would welcome the opportunity to contribute my analytical rigor, empirical modeling experience, and evidence-based approach to GiveWell's research team. Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards